



Giuseppe Garibaldi, in the red shirt that symbolized his makeshift army, managed to overthrow Bourbon rule in the Kingdom of the Two Sicilies but had to compromise on governmental form.

He was also driven by the goal of ending Austrian rule in the north of the country and by the idea of a united Italy. The desire to form new political entities based on common national elements such as geography and history came to be known as nationalism.

Reaching a compromise

In 1859, much of Italy had already been united under the state of Piedmont-Sardinia, in the northwest of Italy, a process directed by its shrewd and pragmatic prime minister Camillo Benso, Count of Cavour, and critically boosted by French military assistance in expelling the Austrians.

For Cavour, unification meant the creation not of a republican Italy, but of a centralized state under a constitutional monarchy. He believed this was the only way that Italy could realize its potential—above all, to press ahead with industrialization and compete with the leading powers of Europe.

The Redshirts' forces, swelled by locals flocking to join them, soon overcame the ineptly led armies of the Kingdom of the Two Sicilies.

When it came to deciding upon a government for the newly united Italy—Venice and Rome excepted, though both would subsequently be incorporated, in 1866 and 1870 respectively—Garibaldi recognized the inevitability of Piedmontese domination. In November 1860, with Garibaldi at his side, Victor Emmanuel II of Sardinia entered Naples. In March 1861, he was crowned king of Italy.

Divided goals

The difference between Garibaldi's and Cavour's goals illustrates the contradictions at the heart of nationalism in 19th-century Europe. Prompted by the notions of liberty and equal rights promised by the French Revolution, nationalism developed an idealistic view of a more just society. National groups oppressed by alien rule believed they should be able to assert their independence as a natural right.

Nationalism was furthermore characterized by a romantic view of the right of peoples to lay claim to their historic destinies and rule themselves: independence. In place of loyalty to an established ruling dynasty, new loyalties to national groups defined by language, culture, history, and self-identity were formulated. The idea of the nation-state became increasingly common, and likewise a belief in the right to national self-determination.

The failure of the revolutions of 1848 in central Europe and Italy, intended to advance these very goals, made plain the resolve of Europe's ruling elites to oppose such initiatives and to preserve the Europe created by the Congress of Vienna in 1814–1815, after the defeat of Napoleon—a Europe of monarchs, multinational empires, and pre-French Revolution frontiers.

Metternich's failures

The new Europe was far from stable, and the principal architect of the Congress of Vienna, the Austrian Prince Metternich, would later admit: "I have spent my life in shoring up rotten buildings." By 1830, Belgium had revolted against the Kingdom of the Netherlands, of which it was a province; the next year, it secured its independence with British support. Similar nationalist uprisings followed in Poland in 1831 and in 1846, both savagely repressed by Russia.

German nationalism

Rising nationalism had momentous consequences, especially in the various states across Germany. The country's unification under the chancellorship of Otto von Bismarck of Prussia in 1871 and »